The key elements towards the end of the electoral cycle are the review and finalization of the legal framework governing the elections; the production or update of the voter roll until its finalization; the deadline for the registration of political parties; the deadline for the nomination of candidates; the electoral campaign period; the definition of electoral constituencies and the allocation of polling stations; arrangements for electoral security; the training of polling staff; the production and distribution of electoral materials, in particular ballots and relevant forms to administer electoral procedures; the arrangements for results management; and the adjudication of complaints that arise during the entire process. All these elements can trigger conflicts, or assist in their mitigation, at various levels and at particular times, albeit with differing degrees of intensity and impact.

ELECTIONS AND THE PEACE PROCESS

Myanmar and its territorial sovereignty have been consistently challenged by armed actors since the colonial era. Subsequent centralist military regimes offered truces to these actors without achieving lasting peace. When President Thein Sein took office in 2011, he made peace with EAGs a major goal of his term. While some old ceasefires were reconfirmed and new bilateral ceasefires could be agreed, there has also been fierce fighting in recent years, including the use of heavy artillery and air strikes. The bilateral ceasefire with the Kachin Independence Organisation (KIO), which was in place since 1994 and gave Kachin State a period of relative stability, broke in 2011 (see Farrelly 2014).

Since then, armed conflict has been ongoing in parts of Kachin State and northern Shan State, and it continued over the electoral period. For the first time since 2009, on 9 February 2015, fighting broke out between the Tatmadaw and the Myanmar National Democratic Alliance Army at the Chinese border in the northeastern corner of Shan State, in the Kokang SAZ. On 17 February, the president declared a state of emergency and martial law in the area, and transferred executive and judicial powers to the commander-in-chief. This was the first time during Thein Sein's term that martial law had been declared. The state of emergency remained in place until mid-November, about one week after the elections.

Notwithstanding the escalation of conflict at the beginning of the